

Galena Peak

*~8 miles, 3300 ft gain
8 ½ hours*

This past Saturday was a free day so I gleefully found the hardest looking HPS hike for the day and I was off. One early morning carpool later I was on my way to Pomona to do the HPS peak Galena.

The Galena Peak hike is actually short and simple on paper. You basically drive out to Falls Campground off the 38 near San Geronio and make your way up the creek until it turns into wall. Climb the slope, continue along the ridge, reach the peak, and exit the same way. On paper it clocks in around 8 miles with about 3300 ft of gain, rather trivial as they come.



What makes this hike interesting and one that isn't done quite as often as others is the headwall, also known as Mill Creek Jumpoff, that you climb to reach the ridge. More on that later.



The entire hike is cross country with much boulder hopping and scrambling up some steep slopes.

We had 15 people total which was a large group for this hike. We started out on a dirt road but soon we were making our way up Mill Creek.



There was varying amounts of water flowing in the creek but it was never enough we couldn't easily step across using rocks.



On the way up we basically just had fun and picked our own ways amid the rocks. The hike changes from year to year as snow melt comes down and completely changes the layout of the creek. Also the headwall is eroding so each year it gets trickier.

The first milestone is the remains of old mine. While others were taking a split break I wandered off and looked for a mine shaft but never found anything



A bit further up the canyon there was a lone male sitting there in his underwear apparently drinking a beer. He just watched us as we went by and I really didn't feel the need to get any closer.

At one point we climbed the side of the canyon and picked up a faint use trail. This was to avoid an area that had impassible waterfalls previously but we were able to get through successfully on our way back.



Ironically this picture is probably the most dangerous looking one I took all day.



Soon we had a look at the headwall.

Basically the creek bed gradually grows steeper until you're scrambling up a dirt slope punctuated with rocks ranging from pebbles to small boulders. You have to watch your footing at times but the slope isn't as bad as I've seen elsewhere.

Instead the major challenge is falling rocks. The slope is such that a decent sized rock can easily accelerate and then start bouncing with enough force behind it to certainly ruin the day of anyone who accidentally intercepts it. Additionally you have to be wary of rocks which fall from the canyon walls on their own occasionally.

Obviously the challenge of getting 15 people (13 actually as two chose not to attempt the climb) up the slope is to position them in such a way as to not drop rocks on each other.

Our leaders were all experienced but unfortunately we were a bit fragmented as we initially started climbing. I was at the back of the front group (we divided into two groups for the headwall) and I picked a route as far away as possible from the others. We had a few near misses due to some people being much further above than others.

There was much cursing and yells of "ROCK!" punctuating our climb.





Once you reach the top your are greeted by a nice sandy area perfect for sitting, eating, and watching the group behind you navigate the climb.



The second group seemed to encounter less difficulty likely because they stayed in a tight group instead of spreading out. A much better approach for next time.



Now we could see the peak itself further along the ridge.



A vague use trail led along the ridge for maybe another thousand feet of gain. The start had some areas requiring care since you are walking across a sandy eroded area where

your feet have a tendency to slide down towards the several hundred foot rocky drop to your right.

After that it's just a slog to attain the peak.



The day was hot and this was the point I really started to feel it since what breeze there was was being blocked by the mountains during this climb.

Soon we made the peak and signed the peak log.



Some of us decided to tromp over to the neighboring West Galena peak which is actually higher than the named Galena Peak. It doesn't have a peak log and it's not in the HPS list but there is a very nice view from there.



The creek bed behind me is Mill Creek, the route we came in.



I managed to snag Wayne before he started down and got everyone together for a group picture. Note Tom Hill (our leader) isn't pictured because he decided to take a nap at the bottom of the headwall rather risk climbing it. One other person stayed back with him.

Now we just had to make our way down in one piece.



This time we had a well organized descent with Wayne playing traffic cop near the top making sure we were spread out enough any rocks coming loose wouldn't threaten anyone down below. It went very smooth and wasn't very difficult except for a few tricky spots.

Once we were down it was just a matter of a few miles of boulder hopping to get out. Of course having passed the difficult part this was the point where I actually got hurt. I was between groups making my way along and stepped onto a rock that turned out to be less stable than it appeared. I went down rather hard, bloodied the usual hands and knees and delivering yet another hard blow to my poor abused hiking camera.



Susan took a spill not long after. It's always the spots where you let your mind wander combined with being tired that seem to get you. You relax a bit once you are off the slope and that combined with being tired leads to mistakes.

On the plus side it makes it look like you just did something much tougher than you actually did if you stumble out of the woods bleeding profusely.



We hoofed it out from there, surprising a few families who were playing in the creek down below.

I actually ran out of water less than a mile from the car having gone through 4 liters.

Total time was around 8 and a half hours to go only a little over 8 miles. Terrain combined with getting our large group up the wall meant we spent roughly half the trip stopped.

The same leaders are leading hike next week on the nearby Yucaipa Ridge but I will unfortunately be unable to attend because I'll be backpacking with friends near San Jacinto. We could actually make out the peak we're planning to do from Galena.

